



THE SMARTPHONE'S ALARM sliced through your nightmare of that school morning when you found you had forgotten to buy the sketch pens you needed for art class. Your mother's tantrum, "How could you forget?" The teacher's scowl, your sinking heart.

Fast forward. Yesterday, while packing her school-bag, your niece realised she had forgotten to get sketch pens. But her mother grabbed her smartphone, placed an order on a 10-minute delivery app, and the pens were at the doorstep before the school bus pulled up.

This is the promise of quick commerce—e-commerce on steroids, redefining convenience by letting us get stuff in less than 10 minutes. Delivery times could be longer during rush hour traffic or bad weather.

But consumers are lapping up quick commerce. Although the model failed elsewhere, it is projected to grow to \$40 billion by 2030 in India. And that's not counting the imminent entry of Reliance, India's largest retailer.

First, a quick look at the players and the action.

At the heart of the buzz is Zepto, founded by Aadit Palicha and Kaivalya Vohra in 2021. Y-Combinator was an early backer. In 2024, Zepto raised \$1.3 billion across multiple funding rounds, the most private funds raised by a start-up that year. Palicha claims Zepto's sales could soon surpass retail giant DMart, one of India's leading grocery chains since 2002 (2023-24 revenues ₹49,533 crore).

But Zepto is not the pioneer. That honour goes to Blinkit, the new avatar of Grofers created in December 2021. Six months later, Blinkit was acquired by food delivery app Zomato, a listed company. Zomato's rival Swiggy listed in November 2024, four years after launching Swiggy Instamart.

Tata-owned BigBasket, which created the online grocery business in 2011 and is Blinkit's biggest rival, has launched BBNow, a 10-minute delivery service. Flipkart launched Flipkart Minutes in August 2024, fetching groceries and smartphones. Amazon is reportedly testing 15-minute deliveries.

While Zepto set a record in funding, Blinkit has more SKUs or stock-keeping units, operates in more cities, and has more "dark stores" or stores serving a

A RAPID LOOK



Blazing Growth: Quick commerce is transforming India's retail landscape, with over 82% of buyers shifting at least 25% of their kirana purchases to these platforms—all within just four years of the sector's emergence



Fierce Competition: From start-ups to giants like Flipkart and Amazon, the battle for dominance is heating up, even as profitability remains elusive

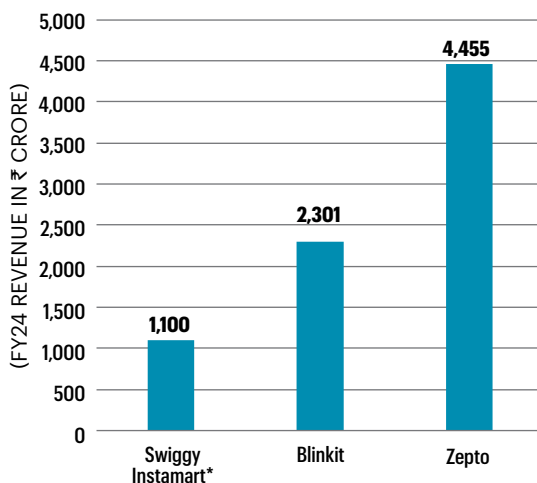


The Big Question: While quick commerce thrives in metros, its expansion into Tier II and Tier III cities raises concerns about sustainability and long-term viability

THE SPEED STARS

● Zepto was the clear leader among quick commerce firms in FY24 in terms of revenue

● Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart are pulling out all stops in a bid to catch up



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